

Another Anti-trust in the making?

EVERY ANNOUNCEMENT MADE AT THIS YEAR'S GDC (Game Developers Confer-

ence) was overshadowed by one service in particular, Google Stadia. Google's entry into the video game streaming business is by no means a small gesture. It's certainly not the first to come out with the concept but Google's certainly leveraging other Google services to build a platform that appears to have a seamless integration. Google has had a lot of issues with getting people onto services in the past. Orkut didn't do well in the US but practically every Indian kid had a profile on it and so Google killed it. Similarly, Allo fell to the axe last month owing to low adoption. To prevent something similar from happening to Stadia, Google is widening the funnel by peppering hyperlinks into existing Google services such as YouTube. This makes Stadia more visible and the convenience of getting started with just one click is too good to pass. Google already has the networking infrastructure that's spread across the world, it's using custom AMD GPUs which are more powerful than current gen Xbox and PlayStation consoles and it's making the service convenient to get onto for users without any initial investment. There's hardly any reason for gamers to not consider this service. Let's consider the cons.

Video games are best enjoyed with low latency! Majority of the gamers all over the world play casually, competitive gamers are only a small fraction of the entire gamer populace. Competitive gamers will still prefer PCs which they've grown familiar with, so much that the PC is an extension of their own person. So ultra low latency isn't critical here. If you've been playing games on your TV, then it's most certain that you haven't experienced low latency. The input lag in mainstream TV units is just ridiculous. You have to enable game mode (or whatever fancy term the manufacturer uses) in order to experience lower latencies. Without that, you might as well play on a streaming service such as Stadia because the difference would be negligible.

Consoles have been using the x86 microarchitecture for a while, which is why you've started seeing a lot more games being developed in shorter time frame since most of the development work only has to be done once. Previously, with proprietary hardware,

games had to be developed separately for each platform. Consoles survive on video game exclusivity and convenience. As the gaming market gets crowded it's becoming increasingly difficult for smaller studios to turn a decent profit which is why we see asinine exclusivity agreements being signed by the EPIC store in lieu of money. And guess who has more money than everyone else on the planet? While I personally don't believe that Google will pull what EPIC did, I certainly do believe that developers wouldn't shy away from a platform that can draw in more people than PC and Consoles combined. After all, the Play Store has access to more people than every other platform. Going by the first Stadia demo of Doom (2016), it seems like some gamers might not go for Stadia till the visual fidelity is improved. Streaming makes use of massive compression and all the niceties of current gen GPU APIs are easily lost with streaming.

So Google has the money, it has the hardware and it has the widest funnel to acquire users. What could go wrong? Well, for starters, the service might be shut down out of the blue. You must've heard this one before. Yes, Google does shut services but only if they don't have users. Gaming is one of the fastest growing sector in the world and there's little reason to believe that Stadia won't amass a large playerbase. My concern is that it might end up killing the competition and that's one of the worst things to happen to any industry. Historically, Google Play Store has had the higher user count but the ones with deep pockets are with the Apple App Store. We all know that Apple is about to launch a video streaming service and leveraging the same infrastructure to venture into the game streaming service wouldn't be a far out idea. Amazon isn't far from unveiling something similar in 2020 and NVIDIA's has been in beta for ages. What's worrying is that if Google decides to hide the competition from search results then it could effectively cripple the competition. We're looking at Microsoft and Sony now. After all, if something's not on Google, then it probably doesn't exist. Let's just hope that the competition pulls its socks up sooner rather than later. **d**



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Let me know your thoughts on this column at:

@mithun_mohandas |
mithun@digit.in